

Manual Labeling Manual Methodology

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Manual labeling of political texts is a commonly used tool in the world of AI and the social sciences. It helps to guide the development of machine learning tools, serving as the “gold standard” against which an AI’s performance is compared. However, this method is very subjective, as the results of manual labeling will differ greatly depending on the coder’s internal biases, prejudices, and experience in the labeling topic. This is why the largest manual labeling projects use at least a couple of dozen labelers so that each other’s biases are canceled out. However, most manual labeling teams do not have a large number of team members, which risks heavily biased results.

In this context, labeling manuals are of extreme importance as they guide labelers, providing specific definitions and examples on how to code each label correctly. This works because labelers are now provided with a consistent and documented reference point to decide on each specific label instead of solely relying on their subjective internal judgment. This, in turn, improves the quality of the labeling, enhancing consistency and the potential replicability of the labeling process. To do so, we have based this labeling manual on the manuals of the Comparative Manifesto Project (Team 2025), a reference in the manual labeling of political texts, from which we draw the structure of our coding manual.

The manual provided is based on entity-centered labeling, which distinguishes between the general sentiment of a text and the sentiment directed at our object of interest, such as a specific political institution, state, or politician. This is crucial, as a comment could express anger, fear, irony, or sarcasm, but the target of this emotion is not necessarily our object of interest. (Kuila and Sarkar 2024) Moreover, the labeling manual employs the appraisal theory framework to scrutinize a comment’s emotion by analyzing its attitude, engagement type with other comments, and the intensity of its expression. (Mažeikienė 2022) (Trnavac and Pöldvere 2024) This is aimed at orienting coders, offering a list of clues on what to look for in a comment’s language to assess sentiment.

Finally, the substantive part of the coding manual defines the following labels:

- Binary measure for Taiwanese nationalism: Expressions of pride, support, or identification with Taiwan’s civic, democratic, or cultural identity. (Cheng 2024) (Chen 2024) (Hioe 2024) (Lai 2024)
- Binary measure for antipathy towards China: Expressions of hostility, distrust, or rejection of China’s political system, intentions, or influence. (Cheng 2024) (Chen 2024) (Hioe 2024) (Lai 2024)
- Binary measure for antipathy towards Taiwan: Expressions aimed at delegitimizing Taiwan’s governance, society, or international standing. (Tatsumi, Kennedy, and Li 2020)
- An ordinal measure showing a negative, positive, or neutral evaluation of different countries other than China. (Team 2025)
- An ordinal measure showing agreement, disagreement, or a neutral stance towards the video’s statement. (Kirdemir and Adeliyi 2023)
- Binary measure for whether a comment challenges the truthfulness or credibility of the deepfake video. (Kirdemir and Adeliyi 2023)
- Binary measure for whether a comment shows signs of being part of a coordinated or automated campaign.

Sources

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